

SKI FEVER
Mohammad Arif Khan has been skiing since the age of 4

and work a bit harder this time around," Khan says.

The pressure was immense at the start of the previous year. At his age, Khan realised that this was perhaps his best chance to make the Olympic cut. He even decided to put marriage on hold after a heartfelt discussion with his fiancé. "She didn't know much about my skiing experience, so I sat down to narrate my journey over all these years and about everything that I have wanted to achieve. I am lucky to have her support and that of her family," he says.

In November, he made the cut for the slalom event at a qualifier in Dubai and the following month, his performance in Kolasin was good enough for the giant slalom. These days, he is being funded by the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports as part of the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS). "My efforts are being appreciated everywhere I go. To be included as part of TOPS is one of the best things to have happened for the recognition of my sport. The Olympics is one of the biggest platforms in the world and I want to use it to introduce India as a skiing destination to the rest of the world," he says.

The sense of relief at having finally made it to the Olympics is apparent—he's the only athlete in the Indian contingent so far. That said, there's a constant voice in his head as he hits the slopes each day. "I keep asking myself why I'm here and what got me here. Those are the words that keep me motivated," he says. ■

–Shail Desai

ABHIJIT BHATLEKAR/GETTY IMAGES

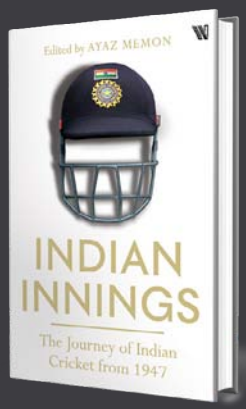
SPORTS

"CRICKET IS INDIA'S HEARTBEAT"

***Ayaz Memon** once aspired to be a cricketer, an engineer, a lawyer. That was all until he discovered his true love–journalism. It allowed him to live the many highs and lows of Indian cricket over four decades.* **Indian Innings**, *an anthology edited by him, tells stories of key moments that shaped the game.*

Q. How does Indian cricket reflect the state of the nation?
That cricket is the heartbeat of India comes through in all accounts from the time the British introduced the sport here. From royalty to commoners, across religions and caste (with hardships), vast numbers of people of India took to this highly nuanced sport with an obsessive passion that has beguiled and befuddled social scientists. At a granular level, the Indian dressing room has been a microcosm of Indian life—its confluences and contradictions, its inherent plurality and inclusiveness, with some chinks appearing every now and then, much as in daily life.

Q. How did the '70s shape Indian cricket?
This was a seminal decade. The chairman of selectors, Vijay Merchant, used his casting vote to remove the Nawab of Pataudi from captaincy. Ajit Wadekar was made captain to tour the West Indies and England in 1971. This was thought to be 'Mission Impossible' as India hadn't won even a single Test in either country till then. As it happened, Wadekar's team won both the series, which not only sparked off wild celebrations in India but also gave the country self-belief. The emergence of players like [Sunil] Gavaskar, [Gundappa] Vishwanath, the presence of world-beating spinners—[Bishan Singh] Bedi, [E.A.S.] Prasanna, [B.S.] Chandrasekhar and S. Venkatraghavan—and the arrival of Kapil Dev in 1978 made the 1970s the decade in which Indian cricket came of age.



INDIAN INNINGS
The Journey of Indian Cricket from 1947
edited by Ayaz Memon
WESTLAND SPORT
₹546; 581 pages

Q. How has cricket writing evolved over the past few decades?
In the early years, it was plain reportage. As the sport grew in India, so did the writing. Writers today must also know how to read balance sheets, law, forensic medicine, et al. Cricket has become an industry with strong financial and legal implications, sometimes infested with crime, too. From the cricketing point of view, the writing has become more analytical, and, increasingly in this millennium, data-backed. That said, a lucid piece, well-written, giving the reader enough to chew on, stands the test of time.

Q. What was the most memorable moment in Indian cricket for you? And why?
Watching my first Test (in 1964), which incidentally India won; Salim Durani hitting sixes on demand (Bombay, 1973); seeing Gavaskar break Don Bradman's record for Test centuries (Madras, 1983–84); reporting on Tendulkar's first Test (Karachi, 1989) and last (Mumbai, 2013); and the magical partnership between Laxman and Dravid (Kolkata, 2001) are some that come to mind. But if I have to pick one moment, it is India winning the 1983 World Cup. It made my decision to remain a journalist rather than pursue law. ■

–with Shail Desai